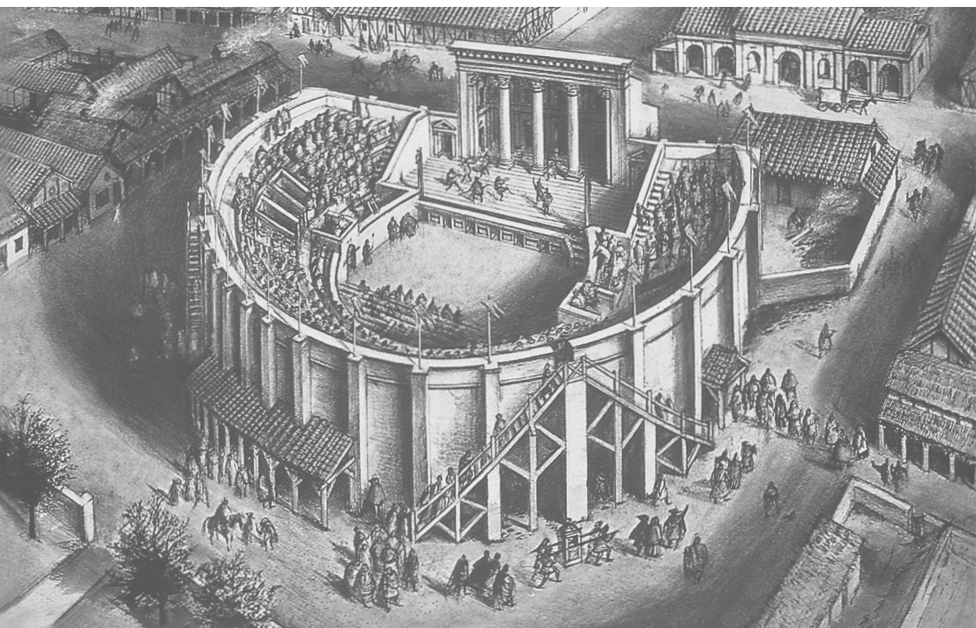




A ROMAN THEATER RESEMBLED AN ARENA WITH THE END CHOPPED OFF.

mastered oratory often worked in law or in politics, where public speaking was important.

Books and libraries

A good education meant you'd be able to read books and poems by Roman and Greek writers. Most Roman books weren't like this one, with pages you can turn. They were written by hand (the Romans didn't know about printing) on sheets of paper made from the Egyptian papyrus plant. Black and red ink was used. Mistakes could be rubbed out with a damp sponge. The

finished sheets were glued together into rolls, each of about 20 sheets, then wrapped around a winding stick (*umbilicus*). These scrolls (book rolls) were stored on their sides in the bookcases of a library (*bibliotheca*). Finally, labels were attached to the scrolls to give their titles.

Watching a play

A visit to the theater was a popular pastime in towns and cities throughout the empire. Roman theaters didn't put on performances whenever they felt like it, as theaters do today. Plays, like chariot races and gladiator fights, were staged on public holidays. But Roman